Through all this, we could not help feeling curious about the German soldiers across the way. After all, they faced the same dangers we did and slogged about in the same muck. What's more, their first trench was only fifty yards from ours. Between us lay No Man's Land, bordered on both sides by barbed wire - yet they were close enough we sometimes heard their voices.

Of course, we hated them when they killed our friends. But other times, we joked about them and almost felt we had something in common. And now it seems they felt the same.

Just yesterday morning - Christmas Eve Day - we had our first good freeze. Cold as we were, we welcomed it, because at least the mud froze solid. Everything was tinged white with frost while a bright sun shone over everything. Perfect Christmas weather!

During the day, there was little shelling or rifle fire from either side. And as darkness fell on our Christmas Eve, the shooting stopped entirely. Our first complete silence in months! We hoped it might promise a peaceful holiday, but didn't count on it. We'd been told the Germans might attack and try to catch us off guard.

I went to the dugout to rest, and lying on my cot, I must have drifted asleep. All at once my friend John was shaking me awake, saying, "Come and see! See what the Germans are doing!" I grabbed my rifle, stumbled out into the trench, and stuck my head cautiously above the sandbags.

I never hope to see a stranger and more lovely sight. Clusters of tiny lights were shining all along the German line, left and right as far as the eye could see.

"What is it?" I asked in bewilderment, and John answered, "Christmas trees!"

And so it was. The Germans had placed Christmas trees in front of their trenches, lit by candle or lantern, like beacons of goodwill.

And then we heard them singing.

*Stille nacht, heilige nacht…*

This carol may not yet be familiar to us in Britain, but John knew it and translated: "Silent Night, Holy Night." I've never heard one lovelier – or more meaningful, in that quiet, clear night, its darkness softened by a first – quarter moon.
When the song finished, the men in our trenches applauded. Yes, British soldiers applauded Germans! Then one of our own men started singing, and we all joined in.

*The first Nowell, the angel did say …*

In truth, we sounded not nearly as good as the Germans, with their fine harmonies. But they responded with enthusiastic applause of their own and then began another.



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